Chapter 10: Kick Butt. Take Names.

“What do I do?” Catria whispered to Hrod. “If I heal Slayde, I’m helping Phyrn. I want Cruia to win, but if I don’t, I’ll be beaten.”

Hrod put his arm around her and noted, “This is odd. I’m worried York is very much going to play favorites.”

“What do I do?” Catria asked again.

“Heal him,” Hrod answered. “You don’t have a choice. I’m not letting anyone beat you, and that would get me punished, and likely half the team with me.”

Hrod went with her, as did Rhys and Sean. It felt awkward healing Slayde, and she couldn’t heal him as well as she could Rhys or Hrod, but she brought his gem up to over half shielding, so York declared him able to fight.

Catria was escorted back to her team’s platform.

“I really don’t like this,” Hrod muttered as York announced the next match.

He stood up and called, “Phyrn is attacking to get Xena back from Cruia.” He motioned to team Cruia. “Do you confirm you have her?”

“We do,” Dillion admitted. “She sought asylum, and we granted it.”

Slayde called over, “Permission to fight past gems going dark for my side. One of our people has been captured by them.”

“Not captured,” Dillion responded rather calmly. “She has been grated asylum. She does not want to live in Phyrn.”

The hate from Slayde could be felt all over the arena as he yelled, “You will give her back!”

“Stop!” York called. “Both teams, fight it on the field. I will not allow either side to fight past gems dark, as no life is on the line, and given the intensity of this fight, it will be five verses five.”

There were some murmurs in the crowd, as Phyrn had just fought and only started with nine, but they still had the people to fight.

Slayde brought Payne, Maeme, Krunt, and Bantha to fight with him, and Dillion brought out Leif, Walker, Henry, and Erik. People were surprised that the new war mage was fighting in such an important battle as his first fight. Then again, maybe Cruia didn’t care if Xena was returned.

Everyone sat on the edge of his seat. Phyrn fought all

the time, but Cruia seldom did.

The Cruian boys didn't look like other teams. The other teams all wore matching uniforms of some sort. Terrian wore blue-gray vests. Aschelle wore lightweight surcoats with tails. Phyrn wore leather. Alfir had no uniform, as all their different faeborn races couldn't really wear the same things to fight, but most teams looked battle ready.

Despite the high stakes, Cruia walked out rather casually, looking like they ought to be working on a farm.

"Win this!" Dillion advised them. "Xena shouldn't have to be forced to marry Slayde. We all know he's pretty nasty."

"On it," Erik replied. "I'll do my best. Are you sure I should be fighting this one? I am new."

"I've seen what you can do in practice," Dillion noted. "I'm making the right call."

Both teams took their sides, and York called for the fight to begin.

Some of the weapons Cruia used were very normal. Henry fought with dual daggers, and Dillion fought with kinves. Whips weren't common, but weren't unheard of, so Erik didn't look too odd, but Leif fought with a slingshot, and Walker had a pair of fire sticks.

Slayde charged at Dillion yelling, "Die! Die!" as he threw the ring at the end of the chain of his shoge, hoping to entangle Dillion's knives and pull them from him, but

Dillion started singing, and let go of the knives. The knives moved around in the air on their own. It shocked the fighters, as Cruia seldom fought.

The fight was on, with Phyrn out for blood.

Phryn was savage, pounding and hacking, but where Erik could strike with his whip, he also had a way of making some sort of invisible shields to protect his team.

When Slayde tried to throw cut Dillion with his knife end and it hit an invisible barrier and bounced off, he yelled in anger and charged at Erik.

Erik whipped at him as he came. Of course, Slayde's shielding held, but he dove at Erik.

Erik quickly moved his hand and blasted an invisible shield with enough force that it didn't just stop Slayde, it knocked him back ten feet.

Slayde charged at Erik again. If only Erik could stand back and protect his other teammates.

Leif suddenly shot a slingball at Slayde and called, "Help Henry."

Erik turned to see Maeme was fighting Henry. Henry had dual daggers, so he had to be up close to fight, and Maeme fought with a club and was very strong, so up close, he was a hard opponent.

Henry's shielding was low, and an arrow suddenly flew at him to take it down, likely hoping to kill him in the process.

Erik put up a shield to stop the arrow and whipped at

Maeme. “I have him!” he called to Henry. “Fight Krunt.”

Henry quickly ran over to where Krunt was charging at Dillion from behind and stepping in the way.

They battle raged on, with Ramere chanting, “We want blood!”

Krunt was the first out, then Bantha, then Maeme.

Slayde was furious that his men were out and none of Cruia’s were.

Henry did end up having his gem go dark, but he was the only Cruian boy out when Dillion struck the final blow on Slayde.

“You’ll regret this,” Slayde hissed as he had to leave the field. “We’ll get Xena back. We’ll get revenge.”

Dillion shrugged and casually replied, “We’ll be back here in two weeks.”

York stood up and announced, “Team Cruia has won. AS the rule states, the attacking team will have the team captain punished if they lose, so now…”

“Wait!” Slayde called. “They cheated!” He pointed to Erik. “He had some invisible shields he was making. That’s not war mage magic.”

York thought for a moment and decided, “I will look into this. Since this is unprecedented, I will go light on your punishment and only have you take five strikes.”

Slayde was furious as he was led to be punished and started to fight the lesser war mages, but York threatened

to make it twenty strikes, so Slayed conceded.

With only five strikes, the punishment wasn't as bad as it could have been, but still, it was ugly, and blood was drawn. Most people were sickened by it, but Ramere was cheering at the sight of blood, calling for more.

After the punishment, York announced that was all the scheduled fights and asked if there were any more attacks. No one called for any, so he dismissed everyone, telling them, "Today has been hard battles. Bruis remains in Terrian's dungeons and Xena remains in asylum. Likely, there will be more battles on these issues next battle day. We do need to work for peace, but we also need to fight for justice, so councilmen need to report their battles to me before the next battle day in two weeks. Until then, remember that there will be no bloodshed outside of the arena. I have lesser war mages who can bring even war mages in for justice."

He took a breath and warned, "Thievery does not draw blood, but the rash of thefts will be investigated and those responsible brought to justice. Under Carlin, the thieving ring has become worse. Under me, it will stop. I want peace. Save all battles and disputes for the arena."

He then dismissed everyone.

When they left, he turned to Emmar, the counselor from Aschelle and noted, "I think there will be plenty of fights to keep the arena going, but Cruia is too powerful. Did you see the new war mage? Something is going to have to be done about him."

Emmar smiled wryly back. “Yes, perhaps he needs to have an accident.” He thought for a moment. “That will be hard. He’s a war mage. He has shielding, very good shielding. Maybe we can get a Faeborn from Alfir.”

“Perhaps,” York stated. “We’ll find a way. There are ways to get around shielding. The accident will happen.”